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35 PREPARATIONS + 4 DECORATING LESSONS

The Cake Decorating & Frosting Handbook

35 Frostings, Fillings, and Finishing Techniques for Home Bakers

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This book is sold for personal use. Recipes are provided for home baking; please check your own equipment, ingredient brands, and altitude, as results can vary. These preparations are based on standard pastry ratios and widely used decorating techniques, not on documented testing of every preparation in this book. Practice unfamiliar techniques on a test surface before decorating a cake for an important occasion.

Always check ingredient labels for allergens before serving to guests.

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PART 1

Decorating Fundamentals

Four short lessons on layering, piping, troubleshooting, and food safety — the groundwork for everything else in this book.

Layering, Leveling, and the Crumb Coat

Before you frost anything, level your cake layers. If a layer domed while baking, slice the rounded top off with a long serrated knife, using a gentle sawing motion and keeping the blade level — a cake turntable or a flat surface you can walk around makes this far easier than trying to cut in place.

Stack your layers with a layer of filling or frosting between each, then apply a crumb coat: a thin, almost see-through layer of frosting over the entire cake, meant to glue down loose crumbs rather than look neat. Chill the crumb-coated cake for 20-30 minutes until the frosting firms up, then apply your final, thicker coat on a clean surface.

The final coat goes on more smoothly over a chilled crumb coat because you're no longer dragging crumbs through wet frosting. Use a bench scraper or offset spatula held at a steady angle, turning the cake (on a turntable if you have one) rather than moving the tool around it.

- Level domed layers with a long serrated knife before stacking
- Crumb coat: thin layer to seal in crumbs, chilled before the final coat
- Chill 20-30 minutes between the crumb coat and the final coat
- A bench scraper held at a steady angle gives the smoothest finish

Piping Basics for Beginners

You only need a handful of piping tips to cover most home decorating: a round tip for writing and dots, an open star tip for rosettes and borders, and a petal tip if you want to try simple flowers. Fit the tip into a piping bag, snip the bag's tip just enough to seat the piping tip snugly, and fill the bag no more than two-thirds full so it's easier to control.

Twist the open end of the bag to push frosting toward the tip and keep even pressure as you pipe, squeezing from the top of the bag rather than the middle. For a rosette, hold the bag straight up, pipe in a tight spiral from the center outward, and release pressure before lifting away.

Practice on a plate or a piece of parchment before piping directly onto a cake. Frosting consistency matters more than skill at first: frosting that's too soft won't hold its shape, and frosting that's too stiff will be hard to pipe evenly.

- Three useful tips to start: round, open star, and petal
- Fill the bag two-thirds full and twist the top to control pressure
- Squeeze from the top of the bag, not the middle
- Practice shapes on parchment before piping onto the cake

Troubleshooting Soft, Stiff, or Grainy Frosting

If buttercream is too soft to hold its shape, it's usually too warm — chill it in the refrigerator for 10-15 minutes, then rewhip briefly. If that doesn't fix it, beat in a little more powdered sugar, a tablespoon at a time.

If frosting is too stiff to spread, it's usually either too cold or needs more liquid. Let it sit at room temperature for a few minutes and rewhip, or beat in a teaspoon of milk or cream at a time until it loosens.

Grainy buttercream usually means the butter and sugar weren't beaten long enough, or the butter was too cold when you started. Keep beating — it often smooths out with another minute or two of mixing — or warm the bowl very briefly (a few seconds over a double boiler, or microwaved for 5-10 seconds, stirred, not melted) and rewhip.

If a cooked frosting like Swiss meringue buttercream looks curdled or soupy partway through, keep beating; it almost always comes back together. This is one of the most common beginner panics, and it's rarely a real problem.

- Too soft: chill 10-15 minutes, then rewhip; add more powdered sugar if needed
- Too stiff: let it warm slightly, or beat in milk a teaspoon at a time
- Grainy: keep beating, or warm briefly and rewhip
- Curdled meringue buttercream: keep beating — it usually comes back together

Storage and Food-Safety Basics for Frostings and Fillings

Butter-based frostings (American buttercream, Swiss or Italian meringue buttercream, ganache) can sit at room temperature for a day for serving, but should be refrigerated for longer storage since they contain dairy. Bring refrigerated buttercream to room temperature and rewhip briefly before using, since it firms up considerably when cold.

Cream cheese frosting and any filling containing fresh dairy, fresh fruit, or whipped cream should be refrigerated and the cake kept chilled until close to serving, especially in warm weather.

Always disclose common allergens — eggs, dairy, and tree nuts appear often in this chapter — to anyone you're serving, and double check labels on packaged ingredients like chocolate or food coloring, which can contain unexpected traces of these.

- Butter-based frostings: fine at room temperature for a day, refrigerate longer-term
- Cream cheese frosting and fresh fillings: keep refrigerated, serve chilled
- Rewhip chilled buttercream before using — it firms up considerably when cold
- Check packaged ingredient labels for egg, dairy, and tree nut traces

PART 2

Buttercreams

Nine buttercream variations, from the simplest American buttercream to cooked meringue-based versions.

American Buttercream

The simplest buttercream — sweet, sturdy, and the easiest to get right on a first try.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1 cup (226g) unsalted butter, softened
- 4 cups (480g) powdered sugar
- 2-3 tbsp heavy cream or milk
- 1 tbsp vanilla extract
- 1/4 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Beat the butter alone for 2 minutes until smooth and pale.
2. Add the powdered sugar in two additions, beating on low to start so it doesn't fly everywhere, then on medium until fluffy.
3. Beat in the cream, vanilla, and salt until smooth and spreadable, adding more cream a teaspoon at a time if needed.

Storage: Room temperature for a day; refrigerate up to 1 week. Rewhip before using.

Swiss Meringue Buttercream

Silky and less sweet than American buttercream, made by cooking egg whites and sugar first.

PREP 25 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 5 large egg whites
- 1 1/4 cups (250g) granulated sugar
- 1 1/2 cups (340g) unsalted butter, softened, cut into pieces
- 1 tbsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Whisk the egg whites and sugar in a heatproof bowl set over a pot of simmering water (not touching the water). Whisk constantly until the sugar dissolves and the mixture reaches 160F/71C, about 4-5 minutes.
2. Transfer to a mixer and beat on high until it forms a thick, glossy meringue and the bowl feels cool to the touch, about 8-10 minutes.
3. With the mixer on medium, add the butter a few pieces at a time. The mixture may look curdled partway through — keep beating and it will come together.
4. Beat in the vanilla and salt until smooth.

Storage: Room temperature for a day; refrigerate up to 1 week. Bring to room temperature and rewhip before using.

Cream Cheese Frosting

Tangy and less sweet than buttercream — the classic match for carrot and red velvet cake.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 9X13 CAKE OR ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 8 oz (226g) cream cheese, softened
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 3 1/2 cups (420g) powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Beat the cream cheese and butter together until smooth, about 2 minutes.
2. Add the powdered sugar gradually, beating on low first, then on medium until fluffy.
3. Beat in the vanilla and salt.

Storage: Refrigerate — this frosting is too soft for long room-temperature storage. Keeps up to 5 days chilled.

Allergens: Contains dairy.

Whipped Cream Frosting (Stabilized)

A light alternative to buttercream, stabilized so it holds up for a few hours at room temperature.

PREP 10 MIN • CHILL 15 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 2 cups (480ml) heavy cream, cold
- 1/3 cup (40g) powdered sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 tbsp unflavored gelatin
- 3 tbsp cold water

METHOD

1. Sprinkle the gelatin over the cold water in a small bowl and let it sit 5 minutes to bloom, then microwave for 8-10 seconds until just melted. Let it cool slightly but not set.
2. Beat the cream and powdered sugar to soft peaks, then add the vanilla.
3. With the mixer running, drizzle in the cooled gelatin and beat to stiff peaks.
4. Use immediately or chill 15 minutes to firm up slightly before piping.

Storage: Keep the finished cake refrigerated; best within 24 hours.

Allergens: Contains dairy; check gelatin source if serving to anyone with dietary restrictions.

Chocolate Buttercream

A simple variation on American buttercream with melted chocolate and cocoa.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1 cup (226g) unsalted butter, softened
- 3/4 cup (65g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 3 1/2 cups (420g) powdered sugar
- 4 oz (115g) semisweet chocolate, melted and cooled
- 3-4 tbsp heavy cream
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Beat the butter and cocoa powder together until combined.
2. Add the powdered sugar gradually, beating on low then medium until fluffy.
3. Beat in the melted chocolate, then the cream, vanilla, and salt until smooth.

Storage: Room temperature for a day; refrigerate up to 1 week.

Salted Caramel Buttercream

American buttercream swirled with a quick stovetop caramel.

PREP 15 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

QUICK CARAMEL

- 1/2 cup (100g) granulated sugar
- 2 tbsp water
- 1/4 cup (60ml) heavy cream, warmed
- 1/2 tsp flaky salt

BUTTERCREAM BASE

- 1 cup (226g) unsalted butter, softened
- 3 1/2 cups (420g) powdered sugar
- 1 tbsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. For the caramel, heat the sugar and water in a small saucepan over medium heat, swirling (not stirring) occasionally, until deep amber, 6-8 minutes.
2. Remove from heat and carefully whisk in the warm cream — it will bubble. Stir in the salt, then cool completely.
3. Beat the butter until smooth, add the powdered sugar gradually, then the vanilla.
4. Beat in the cooled caramel until fully combined.

Storage: Room temperature for a day; refrigerate up to 1 week.

Lemon Buttercream

Bright and tangy, built on fresh zest and juice rather than extract alone.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1 cup (226g) unsalted butter, softened
- 4 cups (480g) powdered sugar
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 3 tbsp fresh lemon juice
- Pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Beat the butter with the lemon zest until smooth and fragrant.
2. Add the powdered sugar gradually, beating on low then medium.
3. Beat in the lemon juice and salt a little at a time until the frosting is smooth and holds its shape.

Storage: Room temperature for a day; refrigerate up to 1 week.

Peanut Butter Frosting

A thick, rich frosting that pairs well with chocolate cake.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1/2 cup (130g) creamy peanut butter
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 3 cups (360g) powdered sugar
- 3-4 tbsp heavy cream
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Beat the peanut butter and butter together until smooth.
2. Add the powdered sugar gradually, beating on low then medium.
3. Beat in the cream and vanilla until light and spreadable.

Storage: Room temperature for a day; refrigerate up to 1 week.

Allergens: Contains peanuts and dairy.

Espresso Buttercream

American buttercream deepened with real espresso — good with chocolate or spice cakes.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1 cup (226g) unsalted butter, softened
- 4 cups (480g) powdered sugar
- 2 tbsp espresso powder dissolved in 2 tbsp hot water, cooled
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

METHOD

1. Beat the butter until smooth.
2. Add the powdered sugar gradually, beating on low then medium until fluffy.
3. Beat in the cooled espresso mixture, vanilla, and salt until smooth and evenly colored.

Storage: Room temperature for a day; refrigerate up to 1 week.

Mascarpone Whipped Frosting

Lighter and less sweet than buttercream, with a subtle tang from the mascarpone.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 8 oz (226g) mascarpone cheese, cold
- 1 cup (240ml) heavy cream, cold
- 1/3 cup (65g) granulated sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Beat the mascarpone briefly until smooth — don't overbeat or it can turn grainy.
2. In a separate bowl, whip the cream, sugar, and vanilla to soft peaks.
3. Gently fold the whipped cream into the mascarpone in two additions until combined and holding soft peaks.

Storage: Keep refrigerated; best within 24 hours of making.

Allergens: Contains dairy.

PART 3

Ganache & Fillings

Nine fillings and ganaches, from pourable chocolate glaze to fruit and custard fillings for between cake layers.

Classic Chocolate Ganache (Pourable)

A thin ganache for glazing or the classic drip effect down the sides of a cake.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH CAKE WITH DRIPS

- 8 oz (226g) semisweet chocolate, finely chopped
- 1 cup (240ml) heavy cream

METHOD

1. Place the chocolate in a heatproof bowl.
2. Heat the cream until just simmering, then pour over the chocolate and let sit 2 minutes.
3. Stir from the center outward until smooth and glossy.
4. Cool to just above room temperature (it should coat a spoon but still pour) before using for drips.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 1 week; warm gently to re-liquefy.

Whipped Ganache Filling

The same ganache, cooled and whipped into a fluffy, spreadable filling.

PREP 10 MIN • CHILL 2 HOURS • FILLS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 8 oz (226g) semisweet chocolate, finely chopped
- 1 cup (240ml) heavy cream

METHOD

1. Make the ganache as in the pourable version, then cool to room temperature and refrigerate until firm, about 2 hours.
2. Beat the chilled ganache with an electric mixer until light and fluffy, 2-3 minutes — don't overbeat or it can turn grainy.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 1 week.

White Chocolate Ganache

A sweeter, lighter ganache — use less cream than the dark version since white chocolate is softer.

PREP 10 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 10 oz (285g) white chocolate, finely chopped
- 1/2 cup (120ml) heavy cream

METHOD

1. Place the white chocolate in a heatproof bowl.
2. Heat the cream until just simmering, pour over the chocolate, and let sit 2 minutes.
3. Stir until smooth. Cool until thickened to your desired consistency before using.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 1 week; warm gently to loosen.

Raspberry Filling

A cooked fruit filling, thickened just enough to stay put between cake layers.

PREP 15 MIN • FILLS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) fresh or frozen raspberries
- 1/3 cup (65g) granulated sugar
- 1 tbsp cornstarch
- 1 tbsp water
- 1 tsp lemon juice

METHOD

1. Combine the raspberries and sugar in a small saucepan over medium heat. Cook, mashing lightly, until the berries break down, about 5 minutes.
2. Mix the cornstarch and water into a smooth paste, then stir into the berries.
3. Simmer 2-3 minutes, stirring, until thickened and glossy. Stir in the lemon juice.
4. Cool completely before spreading between cake layers — this filling works best with a buttercream dam piped around the edge to keep it from oozing out.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 1 week.

Lemon Curd Filling

Tart and rich, good paired with vanilla buttercream or whipped cream.

PREP 15 MIN • FILLS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 3 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (120ml) fresh lemon juice
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 6 tbsp (85g) unsalted butter, cut into pieces

METHOD

1. Whisk the sugar and eggs together in a saucepan until smooth, then whisk in the lemon juice and zest.
2. Cook over medium-low heat, stirring constantly, until thickened enough to coat the back of a spoon, 8-10 minutes — do not let it boil.
3. Remove from heat and whisk in the butter a few pieces at a time until smooth.
4. Strain through a fine sieve, then cover with plastic wrap pressed directly onto the surface and refrigerate until cold and set.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 1 week.

Allergens: Contains egg and dairy.

Salted Caramel Sauce (Filling)

A pourable caramel used as a filling layer, held in place by a buttercream dam.

PREP 15 MIN • FILLS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/4 cup (60ml) water
- 3/4 cup (180ml) heavy cream, warmed
- 4 tbsp (55g) unsalted butter
- 1 tsp flaky salt

METHOD

1. Heat the sugar and water in a saucepan over medium heat, swirling occasionally, until deep amber, 6-8 minutes.
2. Remove from heat and carefully whisk in the warm cream, then the butter, until smooth.
3. Stir in the salt and cool to room temperature before using — it will thicken as it cools.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 2 weeks; warm gently to loosen for pouring.

Strawberry Cream Filling

Fresh strawberries folded into stabilized whipped cream for a light, fruity filling.

PREP 10 MIN • FILLS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1 1/2 cups (360ml) heavy cream, cold
- 1/4 cup (30g) powdered sugar
- 1 cup (150g) finely diced fresh strawberries
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Whip the cream, powdered sugar, and vanilla to stiff peaks.
2. Fold in the diced strawberries gently.
3. Use immediately, piping a buttercream dam around the edge of each layer first to contain the filling.

Storage: Keep the finished cake refrigerated; best within 24 hours.

Allergens: Contains dairy.

Coconut Cream Filling

A simple cooked coconut filling, good under coconut cake or paired with pineapple.

PREP 15 MIN • CHILL 1 HOUR • FILLS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1 cup (240ml) canned coconut milk
- 1 cup (240ml) whole milk
- 1/3 cup (65g) granulated sugar
- 3 tbsp cornstarch
- 2 large egg yolks
- 1/2 cup (40g) sweetened shredded coconut, toasted

METHOD

1. Whisk the coconut milk, whole milk, sugar, cornstarch, and egg yolks together in a saucepan until smooth.
2. Cook over medium heat, whisking constantly, until thickened, about 5 minutes.
3. Remove from heat and stir in the toasted coconut.
4. Cover with plastic wrap pressed onto the surface and chill at least 1 hour before using.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 3 days.

Allergens: Contains egg, dairy, and coconut.

Royal Icing (for Piping and Toppers)

Dries hard, which makes it the right choice for decorations you'll handle or stack, rather than frosting a whole cake.

PREP 10 MIN • ABOUT 2 CUPS, ENOUGH FOR SEVERAL SMALL TOPPERS

- 4 cups (480g) powdered sugar, sifted
- 3 tbsp meringue powder
- 9-10 tbsp warm water

METHOD

1. Beat the powdered sugar and meringue powder together on low speed.
2. Add the water gradually, beating on medium, until the icing holds a ribbon on the surface for a few seconds before disappearing (this is 'flooding' consistency) — for piping stiff details, use less water.
3. Keep the bowl covered with a damp cloth while working, since royal icing crusts quickly when exposed to air.

Storage: Keeps airtight at room temperature for 2 weeks; dried pieces keep for months.

Allergens: Contains egg (from meringue powder, which is typically dried egg white).

Pastry Cream Filling

A classic custard filling, thicker and richer than whipped cream, good under fresh fruit.

PREP 20 MIN • CHILL 2 HOURS • FILLS ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 2 cups (480ml) whole milk
- 1/2 cup (100g) granulated sugar
- 4 large egg yolks
- 3 tbsp cornstarch
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the milk in a saucepan until just steaming.
2. Whisk the sugar, egg yolks, and cornstarch together in a bowl until smooth.
3. Slowly pour about a third of the hot milk into the yolk mixture, whisking constantly, then pour it all back into the saucepan.
4. Cook over medium heat, whisking constantly, until thick enough to hold a trail from the whisk, about 3-4 minutes.
5. Remove from heat, whisk in the butter and vanilla, then strain into a bowl. Cover with plastic wrap pressed onto the surface and chill at least 2 hours.

Storage: Refrigerate up to 3 days.

Allergens: Contains egg and dairy.

PART 4

Decorating Techniques

Fifteen decorating projects, from a first piped rosette to a mirror glaze finish, each with its own short method.

Basic Buttercream Rosettes

The simplest beginner piping project — forgiving, quick, and reliably pretty.

PREP 15 MIN • COVERS THE TOP OF ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 batch American Buttercream (see Part 2)
- Open star piping tip
- Piping bag

METHOD

1. Fit the piping bag with an open star tip and fill two-thirds full with buttercream.
2. Hold the bag straight up, about 1/2 inch above the surface.
3. Pipe in a tight spiral starting from the center and working outward, two full rotations, then release pressure and lift straight up.
4. Repeat in rows or a scattered pattern until the surface is covered.

Storage: Keep the finished cake at room temperature for serving the same day, refrigerated for longer.

Simple Piped Borders

A shell border is the classic finish for the top and bottom edge of a frosted cake.

PREP 10 MIN • BORDERS ONE 8- OR 9-INCH CAKE

- 1 batch buttercream of choice
- Open star piping tip
- Piping bag

METHOD

1. Fit the bag with an open star tip and fill two-thirds full.
2. Hold the bag at a 45-degree angle to the cake edge.
3. Squeeze firmly to build a rounded shell shape, then ease off pressure while pulling slightly to create a tapered tail.
4. Start the next shell just where the last one's tail ends, repeating around the edge.

Storage: Same-day serving at room temperature; refrigerate for longer storage.

Smooth Buttercream Finish

A clean, matte finish using a bench scraper — the look most bakery cakes start from.

PREP 15 MIN • CHILL 20 MIN • FINISHES ONE 8-INCH 2-LAYER CAKE

- 1 1/2 batches American Buttercream
- Offset spatula
- Bench scraper or cake smoother
- Turntable (optional but helpful)

METHOD

1. Apply a thin crumb coat over the stacked, filled cake and chill 20 minutes until firm.
2. Apply a generous final coat of buttercream, working it on with an offset spatula.
3. Hold a bench scraper at a slight angle against the side of the cake and rotate the turntable (or slowly rotate the cake) in one continuous motion, wiping the scraper clean between passes.
4. Smooth the top edge last by dragging excess frosting inward with a clean spatula.

Storage: Finished cake keeps at room temperature for a day, refrigerated longer.

Chocolate Ganache Drip

The glossy drip effect, done by testing on a chilled cake before committing to the whole edge.

PREP 10 MIN • DRIPS ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 batch Classic Chocolate Ganache, cooled to just-pourable
- Squeeze bottle or spoon

METHOD

1. Chill the fully frosted cake for 15 minutes so the surface is firm and cold.
2. Test the ganache's drip distance on the back of the cake first — it should run partway down the side and stop, not pool on the plate.
3. Working around the edge, spoon or squeeze small amounts of ganache so it drips over the edge at varying lengths.
4. Once the edge is done, pour the remaining ganache onto the center of the top and spread gently to the edges.

Storage: Keep refrigerated until serving if the room is warm.

Simple Buttercream Flowers

An easy five-petal flower using a petal tip, good for a first attempt at piped flowers.

PREP 25 MIN • DECORATES THE TOP OF ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 batch buttercream of choice, slightly stiff
- Petal piping tip
- Flower nail (or a small jar lid)
- Small squares of parchment paper

METHOD

1. Fit a piping bag with a petal tip. Stick a small dab of buttercream onto the flower nail and press a parchment square on top to anchor it.
2. Holding the wide end of the tip down and the narrow end up and slightly tilted, pipe five overlapping petals in a circle, rotating the nail as you go.
3. Slide the parchment square off the nail and set the flower aside (on a tray, in the freezer for a few minutes helps it firm up) before transferring to the cake.
4. Repeat for as many flowers as you'd like, then arrange on the finished cake.

Storage: Pipe flowers up to a day ahead and keep refrigerated until you add them to the cake.

Ombre Buttercream Effect

A gradient of one color from light to dark, applied in bands and blended with a scraper.

PREP 25 MIN • FINISHES ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 1/2 batches buttercream, divided into 3-4 bowls
- Gel food coloring
- Offset spatula
- Bench scraper

METHOD

1. Tint each bowl of buttercream a different depth of the same color, from palest at the top band to deepest at the bottom.
2. Apply the darkest shade in a band around the base of the cake, then the next shade above it, continuing lightest at the top.
3. Smooth with a bench scraper in one continuous pass to blend the bands softly where they meet.
4. Clean the scraper between passes for the smoothest blending.

Storage: Finished cake keeps at room temperature for a day, refrigerated longer.

Chocolate Shavings and Curls

An easy way to dress up the sides or top of a cake without piping at all.

PREP 15 MIN • DECORATES ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 bar (3-4 oz) chocolate, at cool room temperature
- Vegetable peeler

METHOD

1. Hold the chocolate bar in one hand with a paper towel (to avoid melting it with your fingers).
2. Drag a vegetable peeler firmly along the flat side of the bar to create curls, or along the edge for finer shavings.
3. Let the curls fall onto a plate or parchment, then use a toothpick to transfer them onto the frosted cake without handling them directly.
4. Press gently against the sides of the cake, or scatter over the top.

Storage: Decorated cake keeps at room temperature for a day, away from direct heat.

Simple Fresh Fruit Topping

Arranging fresh fruit well is its own kind of decorating skill — height, color, and gloss matter.

PREP 15 MIN • TOPS ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 2-3 cups mixed fresh berries or sliced fruit
- 2 tbsp apricot jam or honey, warmed, for glaze (optional)

METHOD

1. Arrange the largest pieces of fruit first, working from the outer edge inward, to establish the overall shape.
2. Fill in gaps with smaller berries, varying the color placement so similar colors aren't bunched together.
3. If using a glaze, brush the warmed jam or honey lightly over the fruit with a pastry brush for shine and to help it hold in place.
4. Add the fruit as close to serving time as possible, since cut fruit releases moisture over time.

Storage: Best added within a few hours of serving; refrigerate if not serving immediately.

Basic Fondant Covering

A smooth, matte covering for a more formal finish — needs a firm buttercream base underneath.

PREP 30 MIN • COVERS ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 lb (450g) rolled fondant
- Powdered sugar, for dusting
- Smoothing tool (or clean hands)
- 1 batch firm buttercream, for the base coat

METHOD

1. Crumb coat and smooth the cake with a firm buttercream base first, then chill until firm, about 30 minutes.
2. Dust a clean surface with powdered sugar and roll the fondant to about 1/4-inch thick, large enough to cover the whole cake with some overhang.
3. Lift the fondant over the cake using the rolling pin, and smooth from the top down with your hands or a smoothing tool, easing out air pockets.
4. Trim the excess from the base with a sharp knife or pizza cutter.

Storage: Fondant-covered cakes are best kept at cool room temperature, not refrigerated, which can cause condensation on the surface.

Simple Stenciled Pattern

A food-safe stencil and cocoa powder or luster dust gives a clean pattern with no piping skill required.

PREP 15 MIN • DECORATES THE SIDE OF ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 food-safe cake stencil
- Unsweetened cocoa powder or edible luster dust
- Small, soft brush or fine-mesh sieve

METHOD

1. Make sure the cake's side is smoothly frosted and the buttercream has crusted slightly (an hour or so at room temperature).
2. Hold the stencil gently against the side of the cake.
3. Dust cocoa powder or luster dust lightly through a fine sieve, or tap it from a soft brush, over the stencil openings.
4. Carefully peel the stencil directly away from the cake — don't let it drag sideways, which smudges the pattern.

Storage: Decorated cake keeps at room temperature for a day.

Mirror Glaze (Simplified)

A glossy, mirror-like glaze — needs a completely frozen cake underneath to set properly.

PREP 25 MIN • CHILL 4 HOURS • GLAZES ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (120ml) water
- 1/2 cup (160g) sweetened condensed milk
- 2 tsp powdered gelatin, bloomed in 2 tbsp cold water
- 8 oz (226g) white chocolate, finely chopped
- Gel food coloring, as desired

METHOD

1. Freeze the fully frosted, smooth cake until solid, at least 4 hours, so the warm glaze doesn't melt the surface.
2. Heat the sugar, water, and condensed milk together until the sugar dissolves and it just begins to simmer.
3. Remove from heat, stir in the bloomed gelatin until dissolved, then pour over the white chocolate and let sit 2 minutes before stirring smooth.
4. Tint with food coloring if desired, then strain for an air-bubble-free glaze.
5. Cool to about 95F/35C (test with a thermometer — too hot will melt the frozen cake), then pour over the cake set on a rack, working from the center outward.

Storage: Serve within a few hours of glazing; refrigerate leftovers.

Simple Watercolor Buttercream

A painterly, blended effect using two or three colors applied with a palette knife.

PREP 20 MIN • FINISHES ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 1/2 batches white buttercream, divided into 3 bowls
- Gel food coloring, 2-3 colors
- Small offset spatula or palette knife

METHOD

1. Tint each bowl of buttercream a different pastel shade.
2. Apply a thin, uneven base coat of the plain white buttercream over the crumb-coated cake.
3. Dab small, random patches of each tinted color onto the surface using a palette knife.
4. Blend lightly in soft, sweeping motions, letting the colors merge slightly at the edges without fully mixing together.

Storage: Finished cake keeps at room temperature for a day, refrigerated longer.

Edible Flower Decoration

Fresh, pesticide-free edible flowers are one of the simplest ways to dress up a cake.

PREP 10 MIN • DECORATES ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- A small bunch of confirmed edible, pesticide-free flowers (such as pansies or nasturtiums)
- Small scissors

METHOD

1. Confirm with your supplier that the flowers are explicitly sold as edible and grown without pesticides — not all flowers are safe to eat, and florist flowers usually are not.
2. Trim the stems close to the flower head just before use.
3. Arrange directly onto the frosted cake, tucking stems gently into the frosting to hold them in place.
4. Add as close to serving as possible, since fresh flowers wilt.

Storage: Add flowers just before serving; they don't keep well once placed.

Basketweave Texture (Buttercream)

A classic textured pattern made with a basketweave or plain round tip, piped in overlapping bands.

PREP 20 MIN • FINISHES THE SIDE OF ONE 8-INCH CAKE

- 1 1/2 batches firm buttercream
- Basketweave tip (or a small round tip)
- Piping bag

METHOD

1. Crumb coat and smooth the cake with a thin base layer of buttercream, then chill 15 minutes.
2. Starting at the top of the cake side, pipe one vertical line down to the base.
3. Pipe short horizontal bands across the vertical line, leaving a gap the width of one band between each.
4. Pipe a second vertical line just overlapping the ends of the horizontal bands, then fill in the gaps with new horizontal bands, offset from the first row, to build the woven look.
5. Repeat around the entire cake.

Storage: Finished cake keeps at room temperature for a day, refrigerated longer.

Simple Number or Letter Cake Topper (Piped)

A piped buttercream or royal icing topper, piped onto a template and left to firm up before use.

PREP 20 MIN • ONE TOPPER, SIZED TO THE CAKE

- 1/2 cup royal icing or stiff buttercream
- Round piping tip (small)
- Printed template of the number or letter
- Parchment paper

METHOD

1. Tape the template to a flat surface and tape a sheet of parchment paper over it.
2. Pipe the outline of the number or letter first, following the template lines, then fill in the center with more piping, smoothing gently with a toothpick.
3. Let the piped shape dry completely before handling — royal icing needs several hours to overnight; stiff buttercream should be frozen until firm.
4. Carefully peel the parchment away and transfer the topper onto the cake.

Storage: Royal icing toppers keep for weeks at room temperature once fully dry.

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